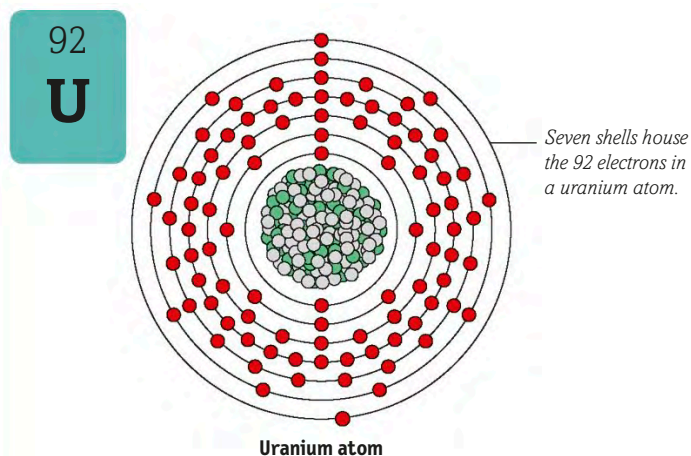
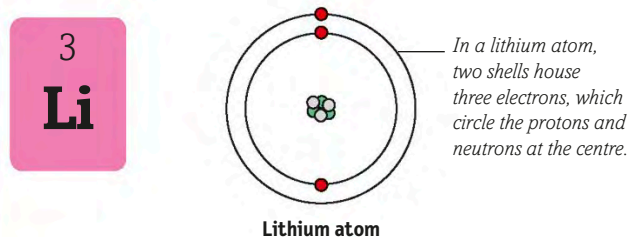
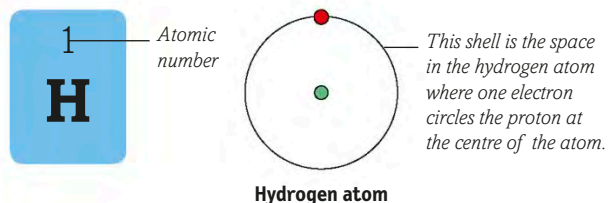


Inside an atom

An atom is the smallest unit of an element. Atoms are too small to see (even with the most powerful microscopes) but they are everywhere. They consist of smaller particles called protons, neutrons, and electrons. Every element has a unique number of protons.

What's the atomic number?

The number of protons in an atom of an element is called the atomic number. The atomic number of an atom identifies the element it belongs to. Every atom also has an equal number of electrons. For elements found naturally on Earth, hydrogen has the smallest atomic number (1), while uranium atoms have the highest atomic number (92).



Electron ➤ The tiny, negatively charged particles in an atom are called electrons. They are involved in the way the atoms of an element react and form bonds with the atoms of other elements.

Shell ➤ The electrons in an atom move around the nucleus. They are arranged in layers called shells. When reacting with each other, atoms tend to fill up their outer shells to become more stable.